

OPERATIONAL REPORTING TRANSFORMATION STRATEGY

Designing a Sustainable Reporting Framework for a Wellington-Based Nonprofit
Organisation

INDEPENDENT CONSULTING PORTFOLIO PROJECT

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Disclaimer

This report is an independent consulting portfolio project developed from observations and experience gained while volunteering in a reporting and analysis role within a Wellington-based nonprofit organisation. Organisation-specific information has been anonymised. The findings and recommendations are intended to demonstrate business analysis and technology consulting capability and do not represent an official organisational strategy or implementation plan.

Executive Summary

Background

Operational reporting enables nonprofit organisations to monitor organisational performance, measure programme outcomes, demonstrate accountability to stakeholders, and support informed decision-making. As reporting requirements expand, organisations often face increasing complexity in collecting, validating, and consolidating information from multiple operational areas.

This report reviews the operational reporting framework of a Wellington-based nonprofit organisation whose mission is to empower women to achieve economic independence through professional styling, career development, mentoring, workshops, ongoing support, and volunteer opportunities.

Business Problem

The organisation uses multiple operational systems, including Monday.com, Better Impact, and Lightspeed, together with physical records to manage day-to-day activities. While these systems effectively support operational functions, management reporting depends on manually collecting, validating, reconciling, and consolidating information from multiple sources into Excel-based reports. As reporting requirements have evolved, the reporting framework has become increasingly complex. Manual data handling, duplicate data entry, multiple reporting workbooks, and reliance on individual knowledge have increased reporting effort and reduced the efficiency and sustainability of the reporting process.

Key Findings

The review identified five key findings:

- Operational data is distributed across multiple digital systems and physical records.
- Management reporting relies heavily on manual validation and reconciliation.
- The reporting framework has evolved incrementally to meet changing business requirements.
- Reporting knowledge is concentrated within a small number of individuals, creating continuity risks.
- Growing demand for operational insights has increased reporting complexity.

Recommendation

Following an evaluation of alternative approaches, this report recommends implementing a modern reporting framework that retains existing operational systems while introducing a central master dataset, Power Query for automated data integration, and Power BI for management reporting and dashboard visualisation.

The recommended approach aims to reduce manual reporting effort, eliminate duplicate data handling, improve reporting consistency, and provide management with faster access to reliable operational information.

Project Background and My Contribution

Background

After relocating to New Zealand, I began volunteering with a Wellington-based nonprofit organisation to gain local work experience while pursuing a career in reporting and data analysis. During my interview, I shared my interest in becoming a Reporting Analyst, which gave me the opportunity to support the organisation's operational reporting activities.

Responsibilities

As the Reporting & Analysis Volunteer, I collected, validated, reconciled, and consolidated operational data from multiple business functions to prepare weekly, monthly, quarterly, and annual management reports. My work involved gathering information from Monday.com, Better Impact, Lightspeed, physical records, and Excel workbooks before producing reports for the Executive Manager.

Key Contributions

During my volunteer role, I improved and expanded the organisation's reporting framework by:

- Developing a structured 12-month Retail Income Report with improved layout, automated calculations, and variance tracking.
- Creating monthly Donation and Re-donation Reports using physical donation records maintained by the Clothing Management team.
- Developing volunteer activity logs for Retail, Business Support, and Marketing teams to improve visibility of operational activities.
- Designing a consolidated Operations Report that integrated information from retail, volunteer management, styling activities, donations, marketing, and customer services into a single reporting workbook.
- Supporting data validation by reconciling information across Monday.com, Better Impact, Lightspeed, and physical records before management reporting.

Purpose of This Review

While developing and maintaining these reports, I observed that operational information was distributed across multiple systems and relied heavily on manual data collection and reconciliation. These observations formed the basis of this independent review, which evaluates the current reporting process and proposes a future-state reporting framework to improve efficiency, reduce manual effort, minimise data duplication, and support more sustainable management reporting.

1. Business Context

1.1 Organisation Overview

This case study examines the operational reporting framework of a Wellington-based nonprofit organisation dedicated to empowering women to achieve economic independence through professional styling, career development, mentoring, workshops, ongoing support, and volunteer work experience opportunities.

The organisation operates through several functional areas, including Retail, Business Support, Human Resources, Clothing Management, Marketing, and Client Styling. These functions are supported by a combination of paid staff and volunteers working together to deliver community services and retail operations.

Operational reporting plays a critical role in measuring organisational performance, supporting funding and accountability requirements, monitoring service delivery, and providing management with reliable information for operational planning and decision-making.

1.2 Current Reporting Environment

Operational information is generated across multiple business functions using both digital systems and physical records.

Primary operational systems include:

- Monday.com — Client and volunteer workflow management
- Better Impact — Volunteer information, availability and volunteer hours
- Lightspeed — Retail sales and register information

Additional operational information is maintained through physical records, including donation registers and client styling forms.

To produce management reports, information from these sources is manually collected, validated, reconciled, and consolidated into multiple Excel reporting workbooks before being summarised in a central Operations Report.

2. Current State Assessment

Current Reporting Process

The current reporting framework combines information from multiple operational areas to produce weekly, monthly, quarterly, and annual management reports.

Data Sources

- Retail income
- Donation and re-donation records
- Client styling information
- Volunteer management information
- Marketing activities

Operational Systems

- Monday.com
- Better Impact
- Lightspeed
- Physical records

Reporting Activities

- Data collection
- Data validation
- Data reconciliation
- Data consolidation
- Report preparation

Reporting Outputs

- Retail Income Report
- Donation Report
- Volunteer Report
- Marketing Report
- Operations Report

The Operations Report acts as the primary management reporting document by consolidating information from all reporting streams into a single operational overview.

Key Findings

Finding 1 — Fragmented Data Sources

Operational information is maintained across multiple digital systems and physical records. Consolidating these sources into management reports requires significant manual effort.

Finding 2 – Manual Validation and Reconciliation

Information must be manually verified before reporting to ensure consistency between operational systems, physical records, and reporting workbooks.

Finding 3 – Evolving Reporting Requirements

Management reporting requirements have expanded over time, resulting in additional reports, KPIs, trend analysis, and ad hoc reporting requests.

Finding 4 – Knowledge Dependency

Maintaining the reporting framework requires detailed knowledge of data sources, workbook relationships, validation procedures, and reporting logic, making knowledge transfer to future volunteers more challenging.

Finding 5 – Increasing Demand for Business Insights

Management increasingly requires timely operational information, including trend analysis, volunteer statistics, retail performance, client styling activity, and programme outcomes to support operational planning and decision-making.

3. Technology Options Analysis

Three potential approaches were evaluated to improve the organisation's operational reporting framework.

Criteria	Option 1 – Current Process	Option 2 – Excel + Power Query	Option 3 – Modern Reporting Framework
Manual Effort	High	Medium	Low
Duplicate Data Entry	High	Reduced	Minimal
Reporting Speed	Slow	Improved	Fast
Data Consistency	Medium	High	High
Dashboard Capability	Limited	Basic	Advanced
Scalability	Low	Medium	High
Long-Term Sustainability	Low	Medium	High

Option 1 – Continue Current Reporting Process

Continue using the existing reporting framework with only minor improvements.

Advantages

- No implementation cost.
- No additional training required.
- Familiar reporting process.

Limitations

- High manual effort.
- Duplicate data handling.
- Limited scalability.
- Continued reliance on manual reconciliation.

Option 2 – Standardised Excel Reporting Framework

Develop standardised reporting templates and use Power Query to consolidate operational data into a master reporting workbook.

Advantages

- Reduced manual consolidation.
- Improved reporting consistency.
- Lower implementation cost.
- Better knowledge transfer.

Limitations

- Limited dashboard capabilities.
- Continued dependence on Excel.
- Moderate scalability.

Option 3 — Modern Reporting Framework (Recommended)

Develop a central reporting architecture using existing operational systems, Power Query for automated data transformation, a master dataset, and Power BI dashboards for reporting and analysis.

Advantages

- Single source of truth.
- Automated data integration.
- Reduced manual reporting effort.
- Improved reporting accuracy.
- Interactive dashboards.
- Scalable reporting environment.
- Faster response to management requests.

Limitations

- Initial implementation effort.
- Staff and volunteer training.
- Additional development time.

Recommended Option

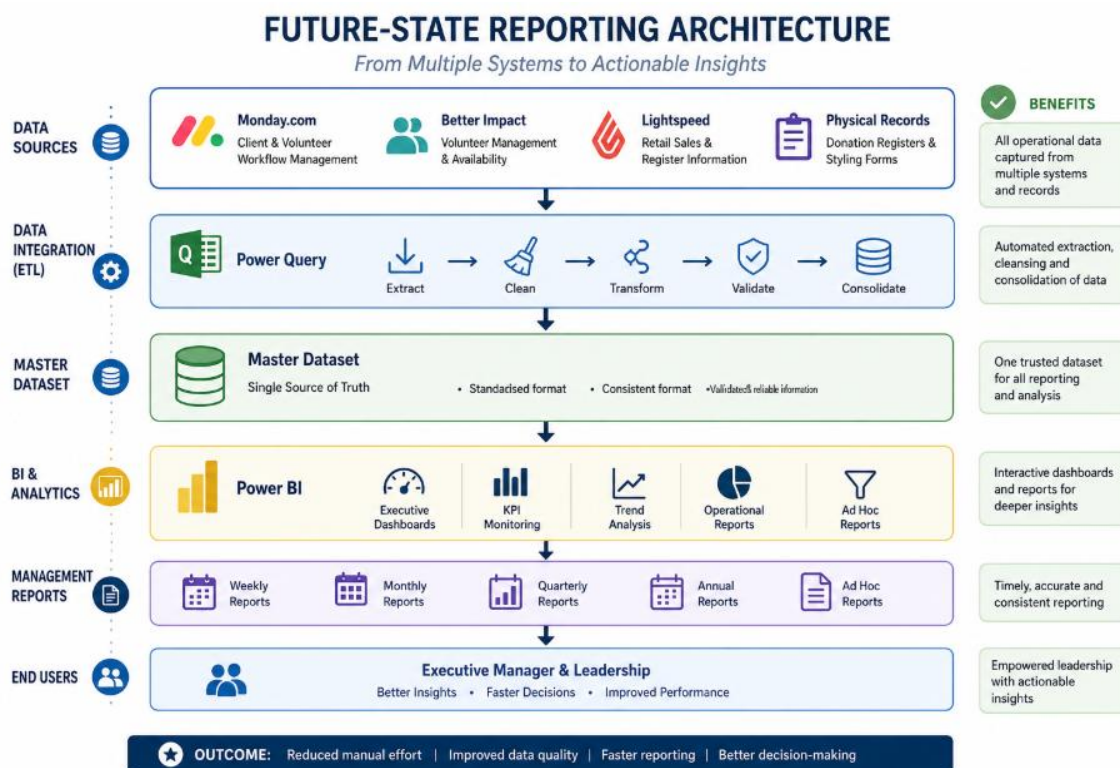
Following the evaluation, **Option 3** is recommended as the preferred long-term solution.

Rather than replacing existing operational systems, the proposed approach integrates information from Monday.com, Better Impact, Lightspeed, and other operational data sources into a central master dataset. This enables automated reporting while preserving existing business processes and reducing manual effort.

4. Future-State Reporting Framework

Proposed Reporting Architecture

The proposed reporting framework introduces a centralised reporting model that consolidates operational information into a single validated dataset before generating management reports.



Expected Improvements

The proposed reporting framework is expected to deliver the following improvements:

- Eliminate duplicate data entry.
- Reduce manual data consolidation.
- Improve reporting accuracy and consistency.
- Standardise operational reporting.
- Enable interactive dashboards.
- Improve response time for management requests.
- Simplify volunteer onboarding through standardised reporting processes.
- Provide a scalable foundation for future reporting requirements.

5. Implementation Roadmap

The recommended reporting framework should be implemented through a phased approach to minimise disruption and support successful adoption.

Phase	Objective	Key Activities	Expected Outcome
Phase 1	Standardise Reporting	Review existing reports, standardise templates, define reporting ownership and common data fields.	Consistent reporting structure.
Phase 2	Data Integration	Build a master dataset using Power Query, automate data extraction and validation.	Reduced manual data consolidation.
Phase 3	Business Intelligence	Develop Power BI dashboards, automate KPI reporting and trend analysis.	Interactive management reporting.
Phase 4	Training & Sustainability	Prepare documentation, train volunteers, establish reporting procedures and continuous improvement reviews.	Sustainable reporting framework with easier knowledge transfer.

Expected Benefits

Implementation of the proposed reporting framework is expected to provide measurable operational and management benefits.

Operational Benefits

- Reduced manual reporting effort.
- Elimination of duplicate data entry.
- Faster report preparation.
- Improved reporting consistency.
- Simplified reporting processes.
- Easier maintenance of reporting workbooks.

Management Benefits

- Improved visibility of organisational performance.
- Faster access to operational information.
- Interactive dashboards and KPI monitoring.
- Better trend analysis and forecasting.
- Improved decision-making through reliable data.

Volunteer Benefits

- Easier onboarding and training.

- Clear reporting procedures.
- Reduced dependency on individual knowledge.
- Improved collaboration between operational teams.

Success Measures

The success of the proposed reporting framework should be evaluated using measurable business outcomes.

Objective	Success Measure
Reduce manual reporting	Less time required to prepare weekly and monthly reports.
Improve reporting quality	Fewer reconciliation issues and duplicate records.
Improve accessibility	Faster response to management reporting requests.
Improve sustainability	New volunteers able to maintain reporting using documented procedures.
Improve decision-making	Increased use of dashboards and KPI reporting by management.

6. Conclusion

This review examined the operational reporting framework of a Wellington-based nonprofit organisation and identified opportunities to improve reporting efficiency, consistency, and long-term sustainability.

The assessment found that operational information is generated across multiple digital systems and physical records, requiring significant manual effort to collect, validate, reconcile, and consolidate data before management reports can be produced. As reporting requirements have evolved, the reporting framework has become increasingly complex, resulting in duplicate data handling, knowledge dependency, and growing maintenance effort.

Following an evaluation of alternative approaches, this report recommends implementing a modern reporting framework that combines existing operational systems with Power Query, a central master dataset, and Power BI dashboards. This approach supports a single source of truth, reduces manual reporting effort, improves reporting accuracy, and provides management with faster access to reliable operational information.

By implementing the proposed framework through a phased approach, the organisation can establish a scalable reporting environment that supports future growth while improving operational efficiency and decision-making.

Skills Demonstrated

This project demonstrates the following professional capabilities:

Business Analysis

- Business process analysis
- Current-state assessment
- Root cause analysis
- Technology evaluation
- Solution recommendation

Reporting & Analytics

- Operational reporting
- KPI identification
- Data validation and reconciliation
- Trend analysis
- Management reporting

Technology

- Microsoft Excel
- Power Query (ETL)
- Power BI solution design
- Data modelling concepts
- Reporting automation

Consulting

- Stakeholder analysis
- Process improvement
- Change management
- Implementation planning
- Strategic reporting recommendations